magnitude. The confidence of monks proselytizing and encouraging the expansion and reach of the relatively new faith will have acquired an altogether new dimension. The closest parallel to this in the West is perhaps the Roman emperor Constantine in the third century CE, whose espousal of the relatively new religion of Christianity—coincidentally, as with Ashoka, roughly 300 years after the birth of the religion—has sometimes been described as a transition of the imperial state into the sacred state. In fact, a detailed comparative study of Ashoka and Constantine—a subject too large for present purposes—could yield fascinating insights into the character and consequences of massively influential monarchical conversions in the ancient world. At any rate, Constantine in Christian ecclesiastical history has the same position of absolute assurance that Ashoka has in the Sangha's versions of key moments in the trajectory of their faith.

Whatever the quality and length of Ashoka's interaction with the Sangha, his message confirms what resulted from it. His newfound ardour was now demonstrated in two main ways. First, he drew attention to the eight months or so that he had spent touring—leading to the surmise that he issued this first edict while on tour. Second, whereas in preceding times humans and gods had not mingled, now in Jambudvipa—Ashoka's name for his empire—the king took credit for making their intermingling possible. This was a way of saying that by creating a shared moral universe for his people with their gods, their emperor had made Jambudvipa a land of greater morality.

In asserting this Ashoka used a motif that occurs in Buddhist literature, one that he must have picked up during his interaction with the Sangha. John Strong, an important scholar of Buddhism, maintains that implicit in this first edict was the idea of a 'double utopia' in which gods and humans mingled either on earth or later in heaven, and that this commingling carried the resonance of what the Buddha himself is said to have created—as recounted in certain texts.[25] Whether the notion was picked up by Ashoka